

What if two engineers differ on the solution, or both have viable answers? Now the entire group can cluster around the weblog and help determine the answer.

Marketing organizations in particular will appreciate a recent use of weblogs to conduct research. Normally, 5-10 people are called into a “focus group” to share thoughts and reactions to everything from product ideas to advertising campaigns. A weblog can generate the same kind of “live” discussion without actually requiring people to gather in one place. Not only does this mean significant production savings, but the responses tend to be more thoughtful and more honest. One company posted a proposed advertising campaign and “sistered” it to a weblog so participants could easily view and respond. Afterwards, all the researcher had to do was review the dialogue thread. There was no need to videotape and transcribe. It had already been done *de facto* - just because of the weblog format.

The value of a weblog is only limited by the imagination. Of course, in order to be actually adopted, weblogs have to prove their worth not only in marketing, sales and R&D, but in accounting, too.

Measuring Business Value

Every company that uses weblogs calculates their value in different ways: For example, what is the return on community? What is the relative cost in time spent creating and updating a weblog to the goal at hand? For the engineer building the heart-monitoring device, the weblog provides him with the answers he needs to do a better job. This in turn helps speed the device to market.

The retail bookstore, on the other hand, realizes value by giving customers a reason to come back. Their weblog builds true brand loyalty by giving readers a chance to interact with a favorite author. Not only does the weblog format encourage higher attendance than an on-site event (people can drop in at their own convenience, from their desktops at home), the retailer saves the cost of traveling the author from store to store for face-to-face appear-